France: energy security, economic opportunity and partnership priorities

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AI-generated from the data and checked against it; paper baseline as of 12 October 2026.

Summary

- France is most exposed in downstream oil and downstream coal, where its Energy Security is higher than only 3% and 4% of the other economies scored. Low consumption scores pull both down.[1]
- Its strongest openings are in midstream nuclear and downstream nuclear, where its Economic Opportunity is higher than 99% and 98% of the other economies scored, lifted by trade and production respectively.[1]
- On the paper's weighting, its top Strategic Index sectors are upstream nuclear, upstream batteries and downstream batteries. Comparing priority with policy, upstream batteries is top priority with the most policy, while upstream nuclear falls in the middle group on policy activity.[1]
- The Partnership Strength Index rates Belgium highest for France, a reliable supplier and its 3rd trade partner. China, its 4th trade partner, ranks 48th.[1,2]

1. Energy security risks and why

Of France's 29 placed sectors, those comparable with other economies, 6 sit in the two low-energy-security corners. Of these, 4 are in the Upgrade corner, which pairs high opportunity with low energy security, and 2 in the Secure corner, where both are low. The paper's framework, after RMI (2025), associates the Upgrade corner with building domestic capability and the Secure corner with securing supply through trusted partners.[1]

Energy Security measures how well a country can rely on what it needs. Its lowest Energy Security percentiles are in downstream oil, downstream coal, upstream nuclear and upstream oil. In the downstream sectors it scores higher than only 3% and 4% of the other 98 economies scored, and both sit in the Secure corner. Low consumption scores pull them down: on expected growth in use per person, it scores higher than only 2% and 1% of the other economies.[1]

Its high-priority sectors, the high-opportunity, low-energy-security ones that the Strategic Index ranks highest, are led by upstream nuclear. There its Energy Security score of 0.17 is close to the sector's median of 0.17, yet higher than only 13% of the other 174 economies scored. On its trade deficit in these goods, <0.1% of GDP in 2023, it scores higher than only 3% of the other economies. For context, its largest suppliers in 2024 were Kazakhstan (30.7% of its imports) and Niger (28.9%).[1,2,3]

Its other high-priority sectors are upstream gas and upstream oil. Both score low mainly because of energy imports and reserves. Production minus consumption was -2.75 EJ for oil and -1.1 EJ for gas in 2025. Both figures take production from the U.S. Energy Information Administration's international statistics, as the Energy Institute does not report it separately. No oil or gas reserves are recorded, which the index counts as zero.[4,5]

2. Economic opportunities and why

France's openings are broad: 25 of its placed sectors sit in the two high-opportunity corners, 21 of them in the Grow corner, which pairs high opportunity with high energy security. The paper's framework, after RMI (2025), associates the Grow corner with export promotion.[1]

Economic Opportunity measures how well placed a country is to create value. Its highest Economic Opportunity percentiles are in midstream nuclear, downstream nuclear, midstream gas and downstream batteries. It scores higher than 99%, 98%, 97% and 96% of the other economies scored in these sectors, respectively.[1]

In midstream nuclear, the score is high mainly because of trade and cost competitiveness. Its exports of these goods reached USD 3.66 bn in 2024, and its revealed comparative advantage is 6.37, so these goods weigh far more in its exports than in world trade.[6]

In downstream nuclear, investment and production push the score up: it generated 390 TWh in 2025, a measure on which it scores higher than 97% of the other economies.[1,4]

In upstream nuclear, its Economic Opportunity is higher than 95% of the other economies scored, mainly because of trade and cost competitiveness. Its export feasibility, a measure of how close these goods are to what it already exports well, is 0.42, higher than 99% of the other economies.[1,3]

3. Sectoral priorities and the existing policy posture

The Strategic Index ranks a country's own sectors by opportunity, security need, policy activity, stage and technology. On the paper's weighting, it ranks upstream nuclear 1st among France's own sectors, scoring 0.68, 0.029 ahead of the next. Its security-need term is 0.249 and its opportunity term 0.175. Next come upstream batteries (2nd), downstream batteries (3rd) and midstream batteries (4th). Upstream and downstream batteries are almost tied with the next (0.000 and 0.009 apart).[1]

In the allied network design, the paper's model of shared coalition production, a member's allied pick is its best-ranked upstream or midstream sector on the Strategic Index after a resource-base screen. France's upstream nuclear and upstream batteries sectors have no recorded resource base, so its allied pick is midstream batteries, ahead of midstream electric grid, the next eligible sector, by 0.042.[7]

Setting the policy term aside and comparing priority with policy activity, upstream batteries, upstream wind, midstream batteries and midstream solar are top priority with the most policy. The upstream nuclear sector ranks 1st on priority but 13th on policy activity, with 1 International Energy Agency policy record naming its technology and stage. In downstream green hydrogen, policy runs ahead of the data: it is bottom priority with the most policy. At the bottom, 7 sectors, among them upstream oil and upstream coal, are bottom priority with the least policy.[1,8]

The Climate Action Tracker, an independent rating of climate action, rates France, as part of the European Union, Insufficient (November 2024). France has 317 International Energy Agency policy records in all, 203 of them naming a technology.[8,9]

4. Partnership priorities and why

The Partnership Strength Index rates partners for France as a reliable supplier (Friendshore), an export market (Partnership Opportunity) and, for middle- and lower-income partners, a development partner

(Development Potential). It rates Belgium, the United States, Germany, the United Kingdom and Italy highest, ranked 1st to 5th.[1]

Belgium, the United States and Italy rank best as a reliable supplier; Germany and the United Kingdom as an export market. As a supplier, Belgium scores best in upstream gas, upstream nuclear, downstream wind, downstream coal and upstream electric grid.[1]

On average across its energy-goods baskets in 2024, Germany is its 1st trade partner, the United States its 2nd, Belgium its 3rd, the United Kingdom its 5th and Italy its 8th. Each is a priority partner with strong ties today, and each votes in the same bloc as France at the United Nations. France shares the G7, NATO and the Minerals Security Partnership with the United States, but only NATO with Belgium. The exception is China, its 4th trade partner: a strong tie today that the index ranks lower (48th), and they vote in opposite blocs at the United Nations.[1,2,10,11]

As a partner to the coalition, France itself ranks 5th of 192 economies. In the allied network design, its derived shares include 5.8% of the coalition's designed production in midstream nuclear and 5.3% in upstream solar.[1,7]

5. Data notes and caveats

Baseline as of 12 October 2026; details on the Country Insights page. Scores compare France with other economies in the same sector; they are not measures of risk or profit in absolute terms. All index values are the paper's baseline as of 12 October 2026; Strategic Insights recomputes them under other weightings. Some figures behind these scores are filled in where the source has no value: with zero where a source lists every holder, otherwise with the world average. Strategic Index scores within 0.01 of each other are almost tied: small changes in the data or the weights can swap their order. Trade figures count trade with other EU members. The Climate Action Tracker rates the EU as a whole; France carries the EU's rating. In the allied network design the European Union is one producer; France's shares are derived from its weight within the EU. Many allied picks are close calls: in the paper, 37% of them are within 0.01 of the runner-up. France's counts leave out the EU's own 438 International Energy Agency policy records.

Sources

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11. Economic-security agreements: G7, NATO, Indo-Pacific Economic Framework, Minerals Security Partnership (and Forum), U.S. free-trade agreements (compiled by the authors from official membership lists).

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Allied Industrial Base Explorer, Country Insights: France